

A FEMINIST APPROACH TOWARD SINO-AMERICAN RELATIONS

Should the US lead China and the rest of the world to embrace feminist policies?

By Alessia Canuto

Political Science student at Luiss Guido Carli University

The White House Gender Policy Council, which Biden and Harris established to develop the first-ever National Strategy on Gender Equity and Equality, represents a once-in-a-lifetime opportunity to promote gender equality and women's leadership. Even though several women run significant agencies in the US, like Janet Yellen, Secretary of the Treasury, and Katherine Tai, the first Asian-American Secretary of Commerce, no country in the world has reached gender equality; instead, we are experiencing an inflection point. The United States has various possibilities to promote its position as it pushes China to do more on promoting human rights and democracy.

"Feminist Foreign Policy: One Path Forward in U.S.-China Relations" is an article by Stephenie Foster, Susan Markham and Rachel MacKnight. They affirm that there is an opportunity to strengthen China's feminist voices thanks to a series of events: internal demographic problems, a crackdown on feminist forums and Chinese President's tacit admission that "wolf warrior diplomacy" failed to arouse international respect. Xi Jinping recently encouraged high-level party leaders to communicate with the outside world transparently and confidently, with modesty and humility. Therefore, I believe this is the right time to approach the Chinese government and people: the Biden-Harris administration could use this opportunity to share experiences abroad and lead by example with a strong feminist foreign policy,

helping strengthen the nascent Chinese feminist movement.

Feminist efforts sparked a grassroots mobilization in China. The case of April 2021 is emblematic, when several feminist groups were censored by Beijing on social media sites such as Douban, Weibo, and Weixin, accusing them of spreading radical political views and ideologies. These narrow forums have supported women's empowerment by avoiding activities perceived as focused or geared towards the benefit of men. A month earlier, Xiao Meili, a feminist activist, had made a post on her Weibo account, denouncing how she was doused with boiling oil while eating dinner with friends in a restaurant after having asked some men not to smoke inside. The post quickly started to be a national matter of debate. But when it became the second most popular topic in searches on the platform, Xiao Meili was accused of separatism and conspiring with foreign forces, referring to the Hong Kong movement.

Many nationalists are using the internet to attack feminists, diverting the conversation away from rights and into the considerably more paranoid and instrumental issue of foreign forces. They overlap feminism with anti-Chinese beliefs, relying on the State-Party's nationalistic and patriotic worldview. This eliminates all possibilities of legitimization for Chinese feminist ideas and practices. Activists who support women's rights have already been targeted in the past. Five of them were arrested for demonstrating against sexual harassment on March 6, 2015.

The "Feminist Five" were imprisoned for over a month before being released amid global pressure, most notably by then Vice President Biden. When the Chinese government managed to bring the coronavirus pandemic under control and presented itself as an example on the international scene, the condition of women has experienced a worsening on all fronts.

Gender-based violence has its historical roots in China and during the pandemic it manifested itself more clearly, facing new restrictions on the freedom of speech and new policies on procreation. The number of working women has decreased in recent years, even though there are more women with higher education than men. Several studies have shown how the pay-gap between men and women has increased and so has gender discrimination in the job market. While in 1990, the 73.2% of women in working-age had a job, in 2019 they were the 60.5%, compared to the 75.3% of men. In 2019 women employed were the 43.7% of the total workforces.

Since 2013, Xi Jinping has emphasized the value of family, asking women to be good wives and mothers. He said that family is the basic unit of the state and that women have the duty to care for the elderly, children, and their education. The insistence on the value of the family and the position of women was further strengthened after the end of the one-child policy in 2015 and the consequent request to increase the number of children, initially two and from 2021 three. In China, birth-rates fell by 2.5 million in 2019 compared to 2018, which had the lowest reported birth rate since 1949. Birth rate is unlikely to increase - in an online survey of the new policy, 29,000 women out of 31,000 said they would not consider expanding their family. Chinese women are not interested in it due to their professional lives, cost of living and gender norms about who is responsible for childcare.

United States and China could work together in the fight against gender-based violence. China's first sexual harassment regulation went into effect in 2005, but until 2020 the country's civil code did not have a legal definition of the term "sexual harassment" and domestic violence wasn't banned until 2016. Through the US-China People-to-People Exchange and other US-based programs, United States could contribute with technical expertise in addressing domestic violence. The next step may be to work together

with local law enforcement, the judiciary, and legal and health-care professionals to strengthen enforcement of legislation, since sexism and the conception of domestic violence as a private fact dominates police action when it comes to acting in favour of women. Gender-based violence, even more than other forms of crime, cannot be reduced to an individual phenomenon since it always involves, directly and indirectly, institutions' responsibility.

In the fight against climate change, a new channel could open up for women's emancipation. It's crucial to remember, as the UN "Woman, Gender Equality and Climate Change" article shows, that women are not only sensitive to climate change, but also effective actors or agents of change in terms of both mitigation and adaptation. Women frequently have a wealth of experience and knowledge that can be applied to climate change mitigation, disaster reduction, and adaptation initiatives. Furthermore, as guardians of natural and home resources, women's roles in households and communities position them well to contribute to livelihood plans that are responsive to changing environmental conditions.

Women make up about 43% of the agricultural workforce on a global scale. This ratio is larger in Asia and Africa, frequently exceeding 50%. The governments of the United States and China can take into account the experiences and responsibilities of women as managers of family resources and community ecosystems during negotiations on climate change. The United States should promote women's economic engagement in their homeland. After the pandemic, the US government should continue to support US economy's rehabilitation and rebuilding, with a special focus on women. During COVID, retail, travel, and hospitality sectors, all dominated by women, were struck the hardest, with many women being fired or quitting their jobs to take care of their children while schools and kindergartens closed.

As the global economy recovers, the US must lead China to increasing health-care spending and improving job flexibility. Better opportunities for women allow the United States to compete more successfully with China while establishing the country as a leader for women in the workplace. Improving gender equality in trade is a tried-and-true method that can aid the US government in more effectively negotiating. To see how gender equality has been a priority in trade negotiations, we just need to go to Canada, the northern border of the United States. Discrimination based on gender is prohibited by the regulations on trade in cross-border services. To improve the working conditions of Chinese women, the US government could implement similar measures in trade with China.

Nüshu, meaning “women’s writing,” was a syllabic script, used only among women to create their own means of expression, since they were denied access to education. In a male-dominated society, the nüshu became a way to escape daily hardships, a parallel universe where they could find complete understanding and mutual affection. Its history must encourage us to focus on an important concept: communication is vital to humankind; hence it is pivotal that it’s not monopolized.

An open cooperation and communication would benefit both China and United States, as well as the entire international community: the Fulbright China program and the US-China People-to-People Exchange are examples of professional, educational and interparliamentary interactions. The biennial International Women of Courage Awards, presented by the US State Department, are already being used to recognize those who struggle to improve women’s political and human rights: China has already produced five winners.

By strengthening the role of feminist organizations in China and the voices of women in both countries, the Biden-Harris administration should use all the tools at its disposal to ensure gender equality and women’s empowerment, as

part of their efforts to reshape US-China relations. Despite the historical and cultural differences between US and China, patriarchy proves to be a transnational problem with no borders. I do feel we need an intersectional and international front in the fight against discrimination, which embraces all particularities and provides practical conflict actions.